BIHARI COLLECTION

NO. 02



BIHAR ORIGIN

# Dal Pitha

Steamed Rice Dumplings with Lentil Filling
A Winter Festival Favorite

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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## Dal Pitha

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

# Dal Pitha

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DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.



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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

# A Dumpling Tradition Shared Across Eastern India

Dal pitha belongs to the broader pitha tradition — steamed or fried rice-flour dumplings found in various forms across Bihar, Bengal, Odisha, and Assam, each region shaping its own version with local fillings and techniques. In Bihar, dal pitha specifically refers to crescent-shaped dumplings made from a rice flour dough and filled with a spiced, coarsely ground lentil mixture, then steamed until tender.

The dish carries strong seasonal and festive associations, appearing especially often during Bihar's winter months and around Chhath Puja, the major regional festival dedicated to the sun god, where various pithas are prepared as part of the festival's elaborate food offerings and family gatherings. Its preparation, often a communal activity involving multiple generations of a household working together to shape dozens of dumplings, has made it as much a social ritual as a recipe.

Unlike some of Bihar's more internationally recognized dishes, dal pitha has largely remained a home-kitchen tradition, rarely appearing on restaurant menus, which makes it a genuinely special find for anyone looking to explore Bihari cuisine beyond its more famous exports like litti chokha.



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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

# A Dumpling Tradition Shared Across Eastern India, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Part of a broader pitha (steamed rice dumpling) tradition shared across Bihar, Bengal, Odisha, and Assam, each region with its own variations. Closely associated with Bihar's winter season and Chhath Puja, the major regional festival honoring the sun god. Traditionally prepared as a communal, multi-generational kitchen activity, with family members shaping dumplings together. Remains largely a home-cooking tradition, rarely found on restaurant menus, making it a distinctive addition to any exploration of Bihari food.



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AT A GLANCE

# Equipment & preparation

| 30m | 30m | 4 | Med |
|---|---|---|---|
| ACTIVE PREP | COOK TIME | SERVINGS (12–14 PIECES) | DIFFICULTY |

## Recommended equipment

- Pressure cooker, for the dal
- Kadai or pan, for the filling
- Steamer or idli stand
- Mixing bowl
- Small rolling pin or your palms, for shaping

### STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Dal pitha keeps refrigerated for up to 2 days — reheat by re-steaming for a few minutes to restore softness, as they firm up considerably once cooled. They freeze reasonably well uncooked; steam directly from frozen, adding a few extra minutes to the steaming time.



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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

# Ingredients

## For the dough

| INGREDIENT | US | METRIC | INDIAN |
|---|---|---|---|
| Rice flour | 2 cups | 300 g | 2 katori |
| Water | 2 cups | 480 ml | 2 katori |
| Salt | ½ tsp | 3 g | to taste |
| Oil, for kneading | 1 tsp | 5 ml | 1 chammach |

## For the lentil filling

| INGREDIENT | US | METRIC | INDIAN |
|---|---|---|---|
| Chana dal (split Bengal gram) | 1 cup | 200 g | 1 katori |
| Mustard oil | 2 tbsp | 30 ml | 2 chammach |
| Cumin seeds | 1 tsp | 4 g | 1 chammach |
| Ginger, minced | 1 tbsp | 10 g | 1 chammach |
| Green chili, minced | 2 | 2 | 2 |
| Turmeric powder | ½ tsp | 1.5 g | ½ chammach |
| Garam masala | ½ tsp | 1.5 g | ½ chammach |
| Fresh coriander, chopped | 2 tbsp | 8 g | 2 tbsp |
| Salt | ¾ tsp | 4.5 g | to taste |



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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

# Ingredients, continued

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Rice flour is widely available at Indian, Southeast Asian, and general grocers in the gluten-free baking aisle. Chana dal can be found at Indian grocers or in the international aisle of many general supermarkets. This dish uses only pantry-friendly, widely available ingredients, making it one of the more accessible recipes for cooks outside India to source completely.



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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

# Making the Filling

## 01 COOK THE CHANA DAL

Rinse the chana dal and pressure cook with water and a pinch of turmeric for 3–4 whistles, until soft but not mushy. Drain any excess water.

## 02 SEASON THE FILLING

Heat mustard oil in a kadai and add cumin seeds, letting them sizzle. Add the ginger and green chili, cooking until fragrant, then add the cooked dal, turmeric, garam masala, and salt. Mash coarsely with the back of a spoon, keeping some texture rather than a smooth paste.





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# Making the Filling, continued

**Chef tip.** the filling should be dry and coarse, not wet or pasty, so it holds together neatly inside the rice dough without leaking during steaming.

## 03 FINISH WITH CORIANDER

Stir in the chopped coriander and let the filling cool completely before using — warm filling makes the delicate rice dough difficult to work with.

**COOKING CHECKPOINT**

The filling should be completely cool and firm enough to hold its shape in a spoon before you begin shaping the dumplings.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

# Shaping & Steaming

## 04 MAKE THE RICE DOUGH

Bring the water to a boil with salt and oil. Add the rice flour all at once, stirring vigorously to form a rough dough. Remove from heat, cover, and let rest for 5 minutes, until cool enough to handle.

## 05 KNEAD UNTIL SMOOTH

Knead the rice dough while still warm until smooth and pliable — rice flour dough firms up quickly as it cools, so work relatively quickly.

## 06 SHAPE THE DUMPLINGS

Take a small portion of dough and flatten into a small disc in your palm. Place a spoonful of filling in the center, then fold over and pinch the edges to seal into a crescent shape, similar to a dumpling.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

# Shaping & Steaming, continued



## 07 STEAM UNTIL SET

Arrange the shaped dumplings in a greased steamer or on an idli stand and steam for 12–15 minutes, until the dough turns slightly translucent and firm.

**Texture indicator.** properly steamed dal pitha should look slightly glossy and translucent on the outside, with a firm but tender bite.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

## Shaping & Steaming, continued

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Letting the rice dough cool completely before shaping makes it crack and difficult to seal. Work with the dough while it's still warm and pliable, re-covering the portion you're not currently using.



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SERVING & PAIRING

# How to serve



## Traditional Style

- Served warm, often with a drizzle of ghee or a side of chutney, as a winter snack or light meal.
- A common preparation during Chhath Puja and other winter family gatherings.



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# How to serve, continued

## Family Style

- Shaped together by multiple family members as a shared activity, then steamed in batches and enjoyed warm.

## Modern Pairing

- Works well as an appetizer with a simple dipping sauce for those new to the dish.



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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

# Chef secrets

## Getting the Dough Right

- Working with the rice dough while it's still warm is essential — it becomes difficult to shape once fully cooled.
- A slightly wet hand while shaping helps prevent the dough from cracking or sticking.

## Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- The lentil filling can be made a day ahead and refrigerated, ready to use once the rice dough is prepared.
- Shaped, uncooked dumplings freeze well, making it practical to prepare a large batch for later.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some households lightly pan-fry steamed dal pitha in a little ghee for a crisp exterior, offering a textural variation on the classic steamed version.



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BONUS CONTENT

# Nutrition, variations & FAQ

## APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

| 145 kcal | 5 g | 24 g | 3 g | 3 g |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| CALORIES | PROTEIN | CARBOHYDRATES | FAT | FIBER |

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

### ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

## REGIONAL VARIATIONS

| | |
|---|---|
| **Fried Dal Pitha** | shaped dumplings lightly pan-fried after steaming for a crisp exterior. |
| **Coconut Pitha** | a sweeter variation using a coconut-jaggery filling instead of lentils, from the broader pitha family. |
| **Til Pitha** | another regional variation using a sesame seed filling, more common in neighboring regions. |

### Can I make the rice dough ahead of time?

It's best made fresh, as rice flour dough firms up considerably once cooled and becomes difficult to shape.



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# Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

## Why did my dumplings crack during steaming?

Usually the dough wasn't sealed completely, or was too dry. Keep your hands slightly damp while shaping and ensure edges are pinched firmly closed.

## Is this dish gluten-free?

Yes — both rice flour and chana dal are naturally gluten-free, making this a good option for gluten-free cooks.



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REFERENCE

# Ingredient glossary




GLOSSARY

| | |
|---|---|
| **Pitha** | a broad category of steamed or fried rice-flour dumplings found across eastern India. |
| **Chhath Puja** | a major Bihari festival honoring the sun god, closely associated with pitha dishes. |
| **Chana Dal** | split Bengal gram, the base of this dish's savory filling. |
| **Ajwain** | carom seeds, sometimes added to the dough or filling for aroma. |



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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

# Dal Pitha

| 30m | 30m |
|---|---|
| ACTIVE PREP | COOK TIME |
| **4** | **Med** |
| SERVINGS (12–14 PIECES) | DIFFICULTY |

## DOUGH

| | |
|---|---|
| Rice flour | 300 g |
| Water | 480 ml |
| Salt | 3 g |
| Oil | 5 ml |

## LENTIL FILLING

| | |
|---|---|
| Chana dal | 200 g |
| Mustard oil | 30 ml |
| Cumin seeds | 4 g |
| Ginger | 10 g |
| Green chili | 2 |
| Turmeric powder | 1.5 g |
| Garam masala | 1.5 g |
| Fresh coriander | 8 g |
| Salt | 4.5 g |

## METHOD

01 **Cook the chana dal.** Rinse the chana dal and pressure cook with water and a pinch of turmeric for 3–4 whistles, until soft but not mushy.

02 **Season the filling.** Heat mustard oil in a kadai and add cumin seeds, letting them sizzle.

03 **Finish with coriander.** Stir in the chopped coriander and let the filling cool completely before using — warm filling makes the delicate rice dough difficult to work with.

04 **Make the rice dough.** Bring the water to a boil with salt and oil.

05 **Knead until smooth.** Knead the rice dough while still warm until smooth and pliable — rice flour dough firms up quickly as it cools, so work relatively quickly.

06 **Shape the dumplings.** Take a small portion of dough and flatten into a small disc in your palm.

07 **Steam until set.** Arrange the shaped dumplings in a greased steamer or on an idli stand and steam for 12–15 minutes, until the dough turns slightly translucent and firm.



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BEFORE YOU SHOP

# Shopping list

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| ☐ | Rice flour | 300 g | |
| ☐ | Oil | 5 ml | |
| ☐ | Mustard oil | 30 ml | |
| ☐ | Ginger | 10 g | |
| ☐ | Turmeric powder | 1.5 g | |
| ☐ | Fresh coriander | 8 g | |
| ☐ | Salt | see recipe | |
| ☐ | Chana dal | 200 g | |
| ☐ | Cumin seeds | 4 g | |
| ☐ | Green chili | 2 | |
| ☐ | Garam masala | 1.5 g | |



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